

KEY TOPIC 1: THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC

Assessment Question: From Democracy to Dictatorship: How did Hitler destroy the Weimar Republic?

Name: _____

Class: _____

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments	
L1: KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919				
L2: KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923				
L3: KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929				
L4: KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929				
Final Unit Grade:				

L1: KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of the catastrophic social, economic, and political situation in Germany at the end of the First World War.
- ☐ Analyse the chronological sequence of events that led to the abdication of Kaiser Wilhelm II, the signing of the Armistice, and the birth of the Republic.
- ☐ Evaluate the democratic strengths and structural weaknesses of the new Weimar Constitution, judging the extent to which it left the Republic vulnerable to instability.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. List the ways in which a major conflict like the First World War might weaken a country's government and economy.

2. Define: What is an 'autocracy', and who held this absolute power in Germany before 1918?

3. Recall: What were the typical beliefs and policies of extreme left-wing and right-wing political groups in the early 20th century?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about what you already know regarding Germany's defeat in the First World War.

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Reichstag | Reichsrat | Armistice | Constitution | Dolchstoßlegende | November Criminals |
Proportional Representation (PR) | Coalition Government | Article 48

Following the sudden signing of the _____ in 1918, furious right-wing nationalists spread the _____ (stab-in-the-back myth), branding the democratic politicians who surrendered as treasonous _____. The new Weimar _____ created a highly democratic system where the lower house, the _____, passed laws while the upper house, the _____, could delay them. However, the voting system of _____ meant no single party could win a majority, leading to weak, constantly shifting _____ alliances. This instability forced the President to frequently rely on the emergency powers granted by _____ to rule by decree.

Active Tasks

Causal Linkage

Q1. Write a short paragraph explaining how the conditions described in Source C directly led to the events in Source D.

Constrained Summary

Q2. Summarize the potential danger of Source E (Article 48) in exactly 12 words.

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q3. Complete these three sentences with historically accurate details: 1) Proportional Representation was highly democratic, BUT... 2) Philipp Scheidemann rushed to declare a Republic BECAUSE... 3) The army felt betrayed by the Armistice, SO...

Causal Linkage

Q4. Write a short paragraph explaining exactly how the British Naval Blockade eventually led to the Abdication of the Kaiser. You must explain the chain reaction of events (the 'domino effect') that connects them.

Transforming Information

Q5. Imagine you are an advisor to President Ebert in 1919. Write a short, urgent memo to him explaining which specific weakness of the new Constitution (Article 48, Proportional Representation, or Coalitions) poses the greatest threat to the Republic, and why.

Vocabulary in Context

Q6. Write a 4-sentence summary of the birth of the Weimar Republic. You must use all five of these keywords correctly: Autocracy, Dolchstoßlegende, November Criminals, Armistice, Reichstag.

The 'Diamond Ranking' Challenge

Q7. You have been given four reasons why the Weimar Republic was highly unstable in 1919:

1. The legacy of the First World War
2. The 'Stab-in-the-back' myth
3. Proportional Representation
4. Article 48

Rank these four causes in order of importance. Write a persuasive, open-ended paragraph justifying your #1 choice over your #2 choice.

Level 9 Challenge: *In your paragraph, use complex causal reasoning to explicitly explain how your #1 cause directly triggered or worsened your #2 cause.*

Exam Practice

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From the diary of a Berlin resident, November 1918.

The city is in complete chaos. Thousands of armed factory workers and returning soldiers have occupied the municipal buildings and are marching in groups through the streets. The Kaiser has fled to exile, leaving no authority behind. Armed workers' and soldiers' councils are declaring that they are the new leaders, and the provisional government seems entirely powerless to maintain public order.

Interpretation 1 (The Superficial Transition View):

The transition of power in November 1918 was fundamentally a superficial compromise that failed to achieve a deep, revolutionary transformation. The moderate Social Democrats, terrified of a Bolshevik-style uprising, made quick alliances with the old imperial elites, particularly the army officer corps. As a result, the judiciary, the civil service, and the military command remained entirely unchanged. This meant the old, anti-democratic power structures survived intact beneath the surface of the new democratic state.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From a letter written by a conservative army officer, November 1918.

The Chancellor, Friedrich Ebert, contacted General Groener. The general promised that the officer corps would place the regular army at the disposal of the new provisional government to restore order. In return, our military leadership expects the government to support the officer corps and immediately suppress the threat of Bolshevism and radical workers' councils.

Interpretation 2 (The Genuine Democratic Victory View):

The German Revolution of 1918 was a genuine and hard-fought victory for democratic forces working under chaotic conditions. The Social Democratic leadership successfully managed to prevent a violent civil war and a communist takeover by establishing a legitimate, representative government. The creation of workers' councils did not represent a descent into anarchy, but rather a temporary, practical method used by citizens to secure political liberty and establish a parliamentary republic.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into The origins of the Republic, 1918–1919? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about The German Revolution of 1918. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about The German Revolution of 1918. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about The German Revolution of 1918? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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Teacher Comment:

L2: KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of the Treaty of Versailles and explain why it made the Republic instantly unpopular.
- ☐ Analyse the political challenges from the extreme Left (the Spartacist Uprising) and the extreme Right (the Kapp Putsch), evaluating why the Republic struggled to maintain authority.
- ☐ Evaluate the causes and devastating social and economic consequences of the 1923 Ruhr crisis and hyperinflation, identifying the 'winners' and 'losers' of the economic collapse.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. On what exact date was the Armistice signed, ending the fighting of the First World War?

2. What was the Dolchstoßlegende (stab-in-the-back myth)?

3. Why did the voting system of Proportional Representation make the Weimar government inherently weak during times of crisis?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about the 'Ebert-Groener Pact' and why Ebert felt he had to make it.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Diktat | Reparations | Spartacist League | Freikorps | Putsch | Passive Resistance | Hyperinflation

Your Sentence:

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson's narrative, explaining the cause-and-effect relationships:

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Write a short paragraph (3-5 sentences) explaining the interconnectedness of the terms: *Diktat*, *Reparations*, *Passive Resistance*, and *Hyperinflation* in the context of the Weimar Republic's early challenges.

Prioritising Causes

Q3. Of the challenges discussed in the lesson (Treaty of Versailles/Reparations, political uprisings like the Spartacist Uprising and Kapp Putsch, and the Ruhr Crisis/Hyperinflation), which do you think was the *most* damaging to the Weimar Republic's stability between 1919-1923 and why? Justify your choice with specific details.

Counter-Factual History

Q4. Imagine the Weimar Republic had successfully negotiated a significantly reduced reparations payment in 1920, avoiding the Ruhr Crisis and subsequent Hyperinflation. How might the political landscape of Germany have evolved differently by 1923, particularly concerning the rise of extremist groups like the Nazi Party?

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why the Treaty of Versailles caused significant challenges for the Weimar Republic in the years 1919-1923 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- **Reparations**
- **The 'stab-in-the-back' myth**

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From an article in the right-wing newspaper *Deutsche Zeitung*, 29 June 1919.

Yesterday, in the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles, a disgraceful treaty was signed. The German nation must never forget this humiliation. On that spot, our national honor was dragged to its grave. We must work tirelessly to rebuild our strength, and there will eventually be revenge for the undeserved shame of 1919.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From a public speech delivered by a right-wing nationalist politician, 1920.

Our proud military did not fail on the battlefield. They were betrayed and stabbed in the back by the cowardly civilian politicians who surrendered in November 1918. Now, these 'November Criminals' have submitted to a dictated peace that forces us to take total blame for the war and pay a crushing, unpayable reparations bill of £6.6 billion.

Interpretation 1 (The Crippling Blow View):

The peace terms imposed in June 1919 were an exceptionally vindictive act of economic plunder that fundamentally crippled the young Republic from its birth. By stripping Germany of its key industrial coalfields and imposing astronomical reparations, the Allies doomed the Weimar economy to constant instability. The harshness of the Diktat permanently linked the democratic government with national humiliation and defeat in the minds of voters.

Interpretation 2 (The Manageable Settlement View):

The Treaty of Versailles was undoubtedly severe, but it was far more manageable than right-wing propaganda suggested. Thanks to the moderation of the Allies, Germany lost remarkably little of its core European territory and retained its massive industrial potential. The true threat to the Republic's stability was not the treaty's physical terms, but the psychological refusal of the German public and the conservative elites to accept that they had been militarily defeated.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the impact of the Treaty of Versailles on the Weimar Republic? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the impact of the Treaty of Versailles on the Weimar Republic. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the impact of the Treaty of Versailles. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the impact of the Treaty of Versailles on the Weimar Republic? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L3: KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of Stresemann's economic strategies, including the Rentenmark, the Dawes Plan, and the Young Plan.
- ☐ Analyse Stresemann's foreign policy achievements (the Locarno Pact, joining the League of Nations, the Kellogg-Briand Pact) and explain how they restored German pride.
- ☐ Evaluate the extent of German recovery by 1929, distinguishing between genuine political stability and superficial economic prosperity.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What were the three main crises the Weimar Republic faced in 1923?

2. What is 'hyperinflation' and which specific social class suffered the most as a result?

3. Why did French and Belgian troops invade the Ruhr in January 1923, and how did the German workers react?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why the Weimar Constitution's use of Proportional Representation was a massive weakness.

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Rentenmark**

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson: 1) Germany's economy experienced a period of recovery and stability between 1924 and 1929, BUT... 2) Gustav Stresemann was a pivotal figure in Germany's recovery BECAUSE... 3) Germany regained significant international standing SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Using at least three of the keywords (Rentenmark, Reichsmark, Dawes Plan, Young Plan, Locarno Pact, League of Nations, Kellogg-Briand Pact), write a short paragraph explaining how Germany achieved both economic stability and improved international relations during the 'Golden Twenties'.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain the causal link between Germany's economic recovery and its ability to achieve foreign policy successes between 1924 and 1929. How did one directly enable the other?

Complex Causal Reasoning

Q4. To what extent was Germany's 'recovery' between 1924 and 1929 a genuine and sustainable improvement, or was it built on fragile foundations? Argue both sides, considering the interconnectedness of economic, political, and foreign policy factors.

Exam Practice

You may use the following in your answer:

- You must also use information of your own.**

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source):
From a private letter written by Gustav Stresemann, September 1928.

Our economic recovery is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is, in fact, dancing on a volcano. If our American creditors should ever decide to call in their short-term loans, a very large section of our industrial and commercial economy will collapse immediately.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From an article in a German financial newspaper, late 1928.

Our national economy has finally achieved genuine stability. Through the Dawes Plan and massive American investment, our factories have been modernized with advanced assembly-line techniques, causing industrial production to soar. Support for extremist parties like the Nazis has collapsed, proving that our citizens are contented and that the Weimar Republic is finally safe.

Interpretation 1 (The Genuine Recovery View):

The period between 1924 and 1929 represented a genuine era of political and economic recovery. Under Stresemann's foreign policy, Germany negotiated the Rentenmark, the Dawes Plan, and the Locarno Pact, which restored national prestige and ended hyperinflation. The coalition parties worked together constructively, and the drastic fall in votes for radical parties proved that Weimar democracy had stabilized.

Interpretation 2 (The Superficial Illusion View):

The economic prosperity of the mid-1920s was a fragile, superficial illusion built on quicksand foundations. The German economy was dangerously over-dependent on short-term US loans that could be withdrawn at a moment's notice. Furthermore, structural weaknesses remained unresolved: unemployment never fell below 1.3 million, small family businesses continued to go bankrupt, and the agricultural farming sector was in a deep depression.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into Stresemann's Recovery? (8 marks)

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3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about Stresemann's Recovery. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about Stresemann's Recovery. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about Stresemann's Recovery? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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Teacher Comment:

L4: KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of changes in the standard of living, including wages, housing, and unemployment insurance.
- ☐ Analyse the changing position of women in politics, work, and leisure, contrasting the reality of their lives with the image of the 'New Woman'.
- ☐ Evaluate the explosion of cultural changes in art, cinema, and architecture, judging why this provoked such fierce opposition from traditionalists and extremists.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the temporary, land-backed currency introduced by Stresemann in November 1923?

2. What was the Dawes Plan of 1924, and what risk did it pose to Germany?

3. What diplomatic agreement did Germany sign in 1925, agreeing to respect its western borders with France and Belgium?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why German farmers and the middle classes did not experience a 'Golden Age' between 1924–29.

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Standard of Living | Unemployment Insurance Act (1927) | New Woman (Neue Frau) | Article 109 | Avant-garde | New Objectivity (Neue Sachlichkeit) | Bauhaus

During the 'Golden Age', Germany's _____ improved for many, supported by progressive welfare reforms like the _____. Women were granted equal voting rights under _____, paving the way for the socially liberated, independent _____ who embraced modern fashion and work. Culturally, Berlin became a vibrant hub of _____ experimentation; artists embraced the realism of _____, while the revolutionary _____ movement transformed architecture and design with its sleek, functional aesthetic.

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete the following sentences based on the provided text: 1) The standard of living generally improved in Germany between 1924–1929 BUT... 2) The 'New Woman' became a prominent figure in

Weimar society BECAUSE... 3) Weimar culture saw an explosion of avant-garde movements SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Using at least FOUR of the provided keywords (Standard of Living, Unemployment Insurance Act (1927), New Woman (Neue Frau), Article 109, Avant-garde, New Objectivity (Neue Sachlichkeit), Bauhaus), write a short paragraph (approx. 70-100 words) explaining how society changed in Weimar Germany between 1924 and 1929.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain the causal links between Germany's economic stability (1924-1929), the emergence of the 'New Woman', and the flourishing of avant-garde culture. How did these three elements influence each other?

Counter-Factual History

Q4. Imagine the 'Golden Age' of Weimar Germany (1924-1929) never happened, and instead, economic instability and high unemployment persisted throughout the decade. How might the development of the 'New Woman' and the flourishing of avant-garde culture have been significantly different, or even stifled? Provide specific reasons and examples.

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why there were significant changes in German society between 1924 and 1929 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- the new constitution
- economic recovery

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From a progressive women's lifestyle magazine, Berlin, 1927.

The new constitution has legally guaranteed our equality with men, and we are entering work and politics in unprecedented numbers. The modern young woman cuts her hair short, wears fashionable clothes, and enjoys her leisure time independently. We have rejected the old, conservative domestic role of our mothers to become active citizens in our own right.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From a letter written by a conservative Protestant group, Hanover, 1928.

We watch with deep concern as our young women abandon their sacred domestic duties. They are encouraged by modern magazines to pursue aimless office work and immoral leisure, rather than preparing to become mothers and housewives. This rise of the 'New Woman' is a direct assault on the traditional family, which has always been the source of our nation's moral strength.

Interpretation 1 (The Social Liberation View):

The Weimar era brought a profound, lasting social and political liberation for German women. The introduction of female suffrage in 1918 resulted in high female representation in the Reichstag, while economic recovery opened up millions of new white-collar job opportunities. This allowed a new generation of independent, financially self-sufficient women to confidently challenge traditional gender roles.

Interpretation 2 (The Traditionalist Backlash View):

The concept of the liberated 'New Woman' was an urban myth that did not reflect the reality for the vast majority of German women. Most women remained trapped in low-paid, unskilled agricultural and domestic work, and the constitution's promises of equality were rarely enforced in the workplace. The visible changes in Berlin cabaret culture actually provoked a massive, hostile traditionalist backlash that weakened the Republic.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into changes in society, 1924–1929? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about Weimar Women. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about Weimar Women. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about Weimar Women? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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Teacher Comment:

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